India had a right to develop nuclear weapons at least to the level of the second-tier nuclear countries of China, France, and the UK. India, he reminded the audience, faced two nuclear-armed rivals on its borders. A Chinese expert, a scholarly and restrained man seated beside me, quickly responded: 'But India is such a small country, and China is such a big country. You cannot compare the two.' It was clear that he was sympathetic to the comparison with France and the UK, but to mention India in the same breath as China was hard to accept. Like the Chinese student who had intervened earlier, he was a genial host and good company over a beer, and there was no hint of a put-down in his manner. It was simply incomprehensible to him that India could be compared to China.

If these are the two leading sets of worldviews of China and India, is there any area of convergence? India sees China as an implacable rival neighbour, as an Asian co-partner in a cosmopolitan world, and as a hurdle to its own aspirations as a great power. China sees India as a tributary, as a junior partner at best in a socialist world, and as an *arriviste* power in the second tier below the US and China itself. A stark conclusion is that their worldviews do not converge and are a source of friction. Only one worldview among the six is positive about the relationship – the Indian view of a cosmopolitan world not obsessed with the nation state, in which China is an Asian partner. This view is also the least likely to have any resonance in contemporary India and China. If there is convergence today, it is in the Great Power–aspiring power view. Indians and Chinese converge on the idea that China is a Great Power. They also converge on the idea that India is an aspiring power. However, India sees China as actively thwarting its rise by threatening its borders and by turning India's neighbours against it. China would say that it is not seeking to stop India's ascent: Indians are doing a good job of retarding their own progress by tolerating bad governance and economic failure.